

WHY ATTEND CHURCH?

(New Believers 101 - 1 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: Hebrews 10:19-25 (NKJV) *"Therefore, brethren, having boldness to enter the Holiest by the blood of Jesus,²⁰ by a new and living way which He consecrated for us, through the veil, that is, His flesh,²¹ and having a High Priest over the house of God,²² let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith, having our hearts sprinkled from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water.²³ Let us hold fast the confession of our hope without wavering, for He who promised is faithful.²⁴ And let us consider one another in order to stir up love and good works,²⁵ not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as is the manner of some, but exhorting one another, and so much the more as you see the Day approaching."*

Luke 4:14-16 (NKJV) *"Then Jesus returned in the power of the Spirit to Galilee, and news of Him went out through all the surrounding region.¹⁵ And He taught in their synagogues, being glorified by all. ¹⁶ So He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. And as His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day, and stood up to read."*

Acts 3:1-9 (NKJV) *"Now Peter and John went up together to the temple at the hour of prayer, the ninth*

hour.2 And a certain man lame from his mother's womb was carried, whom they laid daily at the gate of the temple which is called Beautiful, to ask alms from those who entered the temple;3 who, seeing Peter and John about to go into the temple, asked for alms.4 And fixing his eyes on him, with John, Peter said, "Look at us."5 So he gave them his attention, expecting to receive something from them.6 Then Peter said, "Silver and gold I do not have, but what I do have I give you: In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk."7 And he took him by the right hand and lifted him up, and immediately his feet and ankle bones received strength.8 So he, leaping up, stood and walked and entered the temple with them—walking, leaping, and praising God.9 And all the people saw him walking and praising God."

INTRO: I am convinced; most Christians desire to live an overcoming life. Because this is our desire we normally make an attempt to do the things we believe will produce such a life. Oftentimes the problem with carrying out such intentions is simply the lack of knowledge for why we do such things. I was raised in church but I knew more about what we did not believe, than what we did believe, and why.

In this series of lessons I will attempt to give you Scriptural reasons for the following questions:

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Why attend church?
- Why pray?
- Why read the Bible?

- Why be baptized in water?
- Why receive the Holy Spirit?
- Why serve?
- Why reach out?
- Why tithe?

(My history) In forty five years of living on this earth there has never been a time when I was not "In Church":

- I was raised in a church!
- I was dedicated to the Lord in a church!
- I was saved in a church!
- I was baptized in water in a church!
- I was received into membership in a church!
- Susan and I were married in a church!
- We dedicated our children in a church!
- We have raised our family in a church!
- My funeral will be held in a church!

I am literally a product of the church. Because I am a product of the church, I am a champion of the church. I would fight hell with a water pistol in defense of the church!

I know there are some stinkers (Hypocrites) in the church but Noah had a couple of stinkers (Skunks) on his boat as well but it was the best thing afloat!

Jesus went to church [Luke 4:16](#) (NKJV) ***"So He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. And as His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day, ..."***

The apostles went to church. [Acts 3:1](#) (NKJV) "*Now Peter and John went up together to the temple at the hour of prayer, ...*"

We are commanded to go to church. [Hebrews 10:25](#) (NKJV) "*Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as is the manner of some, but exhorting one another, and so much the more as you see the Day approaching.*"

There are sins of omission and sins of commission, if I disobey a command I have sinned! We have been commanded to go to church, not to do so would be to commit sin.

The example of church attendance by Jesus and His disciples, as well as the scriptural commandment for us to attend church more regularly as we see the end time approaching is surely based on more than an effort to give us something to do to occupy our time! There are many reasons for a mandate concerning church attendance; I want us to focus on seven of them...

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO BE FED SPIRITUALLY!

People have various opinions of what the responsibilities of the Pastor should be but the Word of God makes it clear that his primary responsibility is:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- To feed the flock! - [John 21:15-17](#) (NKJV) "*So when they had eaten breakfast, Jesus said to*

Simon Peter, ***“Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me more than these?”*** He said to Him, ***“Yes, Lord; You know that I love You.”*** He said to him, ***“Feed My lambs.”***¹⁶ He said to him again a second time, ***“Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me?”*** He said to Him, ***“Yes, Lord; You know that I love You.”*** He said to him, ***“Tend My sheep.”***¹⁷ He said to him the third time, ***“Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me?”*** Peter was grieved because He said to him the third time, ***“Do you love Me?”*** And he said to Him, ***“Lord, You know all things; You know that I love You.”*** Jesus said to him, ***“Feed My sheep.”***

- To preach and teach the Word of God! - Acts 6:1-4 (NKJV) ***“Now in those days, when the number of the disciples was multiplying, there arose a complaint against the Hebrews by the Hellenists, because their widows were neglected in the daily distribution.² Then the twelve summoned the multitude of the disciples and said, “It is not desirable that we should leave the word of God and serve tables.³ “Therefore, brethren, seek out from among you seven men of good reputation, full of the Holy Spirit and wisdom, whom we may appoint over this business;⁴ “but we will give ourselves continually to prayer and to the ministry of the word.””***
- To equip Gods people for works of ministry! - Ephesians 4:11-13 (NKJV) ***“And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers,¹²***

for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ,¹³ till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ."

If we are a faithful church attendee and the pastor discharges his responsibly he will not only preach to us but teach us line upon line, precept upon precept, all the while building us up in our most Holy faith.

If we attend church faithfully we will be surprised at how often the word of God will discern what we are dealing with or anticipate what we will be dealing with. [Hebrews 4:12](#) (NKJV) ***"For the word of God is living and powerful, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the division of soul and spirit, and of joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart."***

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO FUNCTION AS A BODY!

When we connect ourselves as we should to a local church it helps us realize we are a part of something [bigger](#) than we are. Being connected to a local church aids us in our attempt to understand what it means to be a part of the corporate or triumphant church.

[Matthew 16:18](#) ***"And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it."***

Being connected to the local church points up the fact, we should make a contribution to other believers, by offering up our abilities in service to them.

When we are a faithful part of the local church we become aware of the importance of every other member of the local church. [1 Corinthians 12:18-20, 27](#) (NKJV) *"But now God has set the members, each one of them, in the body just as He pleased.19 And if they were all one member, where would the body be? 20 But now indeed there are many members, yet one body. - 27 Now you are the body of Christ, and members individually."* Every member of the body is vitally important.

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO BE UNDER SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY!

All authority comes from the Lord. [When we connect to a proper local church we will be taught to submit to both civil and spiritual authority!](#) All of us have a need to be under authority. [Matthew 8:5-13](#) (NKJV) *"Now when Jesus had entered Capernaum, a centurion came to Him, pleading with Him,6 saying, "Lord, my servant is lying at home paralyzed, dreadfully tormented."7 And Jesus said to him, "**I will come and heal him.**"8 The centurion answered and said, "Lord, I am not worthy that You should come under my roof. But only speak a word, and my servant will be healed.9 "For I also am a man under authority, having soldiers under me. And I say to this one, 'Go,' and he goes; and to another, 'Come,' and he comes; and to my servant, 'Do this,' and he does it."10 When*

Jesus heard it, He marveled, and said to those who followed, “Assuredly, I say to you, I have not found such great faith, not even in Israel!”¹¹ “And I say to you that many will come from east and west, and sit down with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven.”¹² “But the sons of the kingdom will be cast out into outer darkness. There will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.”¹³ Then Jesus said to the centurion, “Go your way; and as you have believed, so let it be done for you.” And his servant was healed that same hour.”

Faithful church attendance teaches us the need to submit to spiritual authority. (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME) We come to realize God has placed a line of authority within the local church for its proper governance:

- Jesus is the good Shepherd!
- The Pastor is the under shepherd!
- Local leaders are called alongside the Pastor for the purpose of implementing the vision God has given to the Pastor!

Any kind of variance from this scriptural model leads to anarchy and division!

When we are closely enough connected to the local church to see its proper operation it gives us a model to govern our families.

Everyone needs accountability! Power corrupts, but absolute power, absolutely corrupts!

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH FOR THE OPPORTUNITY TO SERVE!

A call to follow Jesus is synonymous with a call to service. When Jesus called His disciples he said, *"Follow me and I will make you fishers of men."*

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

We are to serve in the following ways:

- Serve God - One way of serving God is to worship Him.
- Serve others - Matthew 25:34-40 (NKJV)
"Then the King will say to those on His right hand, 'Come, you blessed of My Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world:35 'for I was hungry and you gave Me food; I was thirsty and you gave Me drink; I was a stranger and you took Me in;36 'I was naked and you clothed Me; I was sick and you visited Me; I was in prison and you came to Me.'37 "Then the righteous will answer Him, saying, 'Lord, when did we see You hungry and feed You, or thirsty and give You drink?38 'When did we see You a stranger and take You in, or naked and clothe You?39 'Or when did we see You sick, or in prison, and come to You?'40 "And the King will answer and say to them, 'Assuredly, I say to you, inasmuch as you did it to one of the least of these My brethren, you did it to Me."
- Serve the world - John 3:16 NKJV) *"For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life."*

We cannot fulfill our purpose without satisfying these three things.

All three of these areas of service can be performed more effectively when the believer is working in conjunction with the local church.

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH FOR THE OPPORTUNITY TO DEVELOP OUR GIFTS!

Every believer has natural gifts and abilities that they were born with. The reason we were born with these abilities is because they will fold perfectly into the spiritual gifts God will give us as we attempt to fulfill the purpose of God for our lives.

The best place on the planet for developing our gifts is the local church. (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) Think of all the movie stars and recording artists that got their start in the church:

- Elvis Presley
- Dolly Parton
- Reba McEntire
- The Gatlin Brothers
- Naomi Judd
- Charlie Daniels
- Usher
- Ludicrous
- Good Charlotte
- Mandy Moore
- Outcast Kanye (Con-yea) West

- Jessica and Ashley Simpson (Their dad was a preacher)

I would be afraid to have my gifts developed in the church and then use them in the world.

The development of our gifts is the process of walking out our destiny. We are following HIM one step at a time as HE develops us; moves us closer to our destiny; and then takes us to the next level of development which was no doubt His original intention. 2 Peter 3:18 (NKJV) "**Grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ...**"

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO SHARE IN WORLD EVANGELISM!

The will of God for every believer and every church is the pooling of our efforts and finances in an attempt to evangelize the world. Mark 16:15 (NKJV) "***And He said to them, Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.***"

WE SHOULD ATTEND CHURCH TO RECEIVE THE MINISTRY GIFTS OF OTHERS!

No person is an island to themselves. We all need to serve others but we all need to be served by others as well. Believers who attempt to live their lives solo miss the blessing of serving and being served.
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

ILLUSTRATION:

A member of a certain church, who previously had been attending services regularly, suddenly stopped coming to church. After a few weeks, the Pastor decided to visit.

The Pastor found the man at home alone, sitting before a blazing fire. Guessing the reason for his Pastor's visit, the man welcomed him, led him to a comfortable chair near the fireplace and waited. The pastor made himself at home but said nothing. In the grave silence, he contemplated the dance of the flames around the burning logs.

After some minutes, the Pastor took the fire tongs, carefully picked up a brightly burning ember and placed it to one side of the hearth all alone. Then he sat back in his chair, still silent. The host watched all this in quiet contemplation. As the one lone ember's flame flickered and diminished, there was a momentary glow and then its fire was no more. Soon it was cold and lifeless. The Pastor glanced at his watch and realized it was time to leave; he slowly stood up, picked up the cold, dead ember and placed it back In the middle of the fire. Immediately it began to glow, once more with the light and warmth of the burning coals around it. As the Pastor reached the door to leave his host said with a tear running down his cheek, "Thank you so much for your visit and especially for the fiery sermon. I will be back in church next Sunday."

God ordained the church for the purpose of ministering to the saints and reaching the world. We cannot very

well reach the world if we are not receiving ministry from others.

What better place to receive ministry than the local church?

Take a moment to think about what kind of a Christian you would be if the following were not available to you: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- No other Christians to fellowship with.
- No teachers to teach you.
- No discipleship to train you.
- No Pastor to shepherd you; counsel you; marry you; or bury you.

CONCLUSION:

I want to close with this question:

(LEAVE THIS QUESTION UP FOR THE
REMAINDER OF THE SERVICE)

What kind of church would this church be, if every member were just like me?

Can we commit ourselves today to making this a much better church by being faithful with our attendance?

WHY PRAY?

(New Believers 101 - 2 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: Luke 18:1-5 (NKJV) *"Then He spoke a parable to them, that men always ought to pray and not lose heart,² saying: ***"There was in a certain city a judge who did not fear God nor regard man.***³ ***"Now there was a widow in that city; and she came to him, saying, 'Get justice for me from my adversary.'***⁴ ***"And he would not for a while; but afterward he said within himself, 'Though I do not fear God nor regard man,***⁵ ***'yet because this widow troubles me I will avenge her, lest by her continual coming she weary me.'***"*

Matthew 7:7-8 (NKJV) ***"Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you.***⁸ ***"For everyone who asks receives, and he who seeks finds, and to him who knocks it will be opened."***

Ephesians 6:18-20 (NKJV) ***"Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, being watchful to this end with all perseverance and supplication for all the saints—¹⁹ and for me, that utterance may be given to me, that I may open my mouth boldly to make known the mystery of the gospel,²⁰ for which I am an ambassador in chains; that in it I may speak boldly, as I ought to speak."***

INTRO: Prayer is a subject that transcends all religious barriers. Every religion has their own idea of the proper means, times and reasons for prayer.

Various religions pray to a diversity of gods: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Muslim and Islamic believers pray to Allah, five times a day
- Buddhist believers pray to Buddha
- Hindu believers pray to hundreds of gods, 2 times a day
- Jewish believers pray to Yahweh, three times a day
- Catholics pray to Mary
- All Christians pray to Jehovah, the one true God.

The thing that sets the prayers of the Christian apart from all others is that other religions pray to dead deities, we pray to THE God who is very much alive. (My dad once had a bumper sticker on his vehicle that said: "My God's not dead, sorry about yours!")

Peter Kreeft, Author and professor of theology at Boston College made this observation concerning prayer: *"I strongly suspect that if we saw all the difference even the tiniest of our prayers make, and all the people those little prayers were destined to affect, and all the consequences of those prayers down*

through the centuries, we would be so paralyzed with awe at the power of prayer that we would be unable to get up off of our knees for the rest of our lives."

The Word of God makes it clear; **prayer is the act of communicating with God.** (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) When teaching believers to pray Jesus said, *"Our Father which art in Heaven..."* If prayer is the means of communication between an earthly believer and his Heavenly Father the earthly believer should look forward to speaking with his Father/Mentor!

We should pray for the following reasons...

PRAYER IS REQUIRED; TO BE FORGIVEN!

Psalm 32:1-6 (NKJV) *"A Psalm of David. Blessed is he whose transgression is forgiven, Whose sin is covered. 2 Blessed is the man to whom the LORD does not impute iniquity, And in whose spirit there is no deceit. 3 When I kept silent, my bones grew old Through my groaning all the day long. 4 For day and night Your hand was heavy upon me; My vitality was turned into the drought of summer. Selah 5 I acknowledged my sin to You, And my iniquity I have not hidden. I said, "I will confess my transgressions to the LORD," And You forgave the iniquity of my sin. Selah 6 For this cause everyone who is godly shall pray to You In a time when You may be found; Surely in a flood of great waters They shall not come near him."*

The Psalmist begins by saying, happy; fortunate; to be envied; is the person whose transgressions are

forgiven; whose sins are covered; toward whom the Lord does not keep a record of wrongs committed; in whose spirit there is no deceit. (Vs, 1&2) The Hemphills made popular a song that said, *"I'm not perfect, just forgiven..."*

The greatest miracle that could ever be performed is for God to forgive a sin.

The process of forgiveness looks like this: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Acknowledgement - Forgiveness of sins begins with an individual verbalizing (praying) his sinful condition. Vs. 5 *"I acknowledged my sin to You..."*
- Confession - Vs. 5 *"I will confess my transgressions to the LORD..."*
- Forgiveness - Vs.5 *"You forgave the iniquity of my sin."*

The Psalmist states that as long as he kept silent he grew increasingly miserable (Probably because of conviction). Vs. 3&4 *"When I kept silent, my bones grew old Through my groaning all the day long. 4 For day and night Your hand was heavy upon me; My vitality was turned into the drought of summer."*

Notice what he states the end result will be. Vs. 6 *"For this cause everyone who is godly shall pray to You In a time when You may be found; Surely in a flood of great waters They shall not come near him."*

We should pray continually to be sure we do not harbor un-confessed sin.

PRAYER IS REQUIRED; TO DEVELOP AN INTIMATE RELATIONSHIP WITH GOD!

Psalm 116:1-9 (LB) *"I love the Lord because he hears my prayers and answers them. 2 Because he bends down and listens, I will pray as long as I breathe! 3 Death stared me in the face—I was frightened and sad. 4 Then I cried, "Lord, save me!" 5 How kind he is! How good he is! So merciful, this God of ours! 6 The Lord protects the simple and the childlike; I was facing death, and then he saved me. 7 Now I can relax. For the Lord has done this wonderful miracle for me. 8 He has saved me from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling. 9 I shall live! Yes, in his presence—here on earth!"*

The writer here let's us know that he is a praying person and the habit of prayer has caused him to know that God hears and answers prayer. Vs. 1 *"I love the Lord because he hears my prayers and answers them."*

The practice of prayer has led to an intimate relationship between God and the Psalmist. Vs. 2 *"He bends down and listens..."*

For the believer, all intimacy is born out of trust. Through his prayer life the Psalmist has learned to trust God. Vs. 3-9 *"Death stared me in the face—I was frightened and sad. 4 Then I cried, "Lord, save me!" 5 How kind he is! How good he is! So merciful,*

this God of ours! 6 The Lord protects the simple and the childlike; I was facing death, and then he saved me. 7 Now I can relax. For the Lord has done this wonderful miracle for me. 8 He has saved me from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling. 9 I shall live! Yes, in his presence—here on earth!"

We should practice prayer for the purpose of developing intimacy with God.

PRAYER IS REQUIRED; TO MAINTAIN PURITY!

A believer can lose out with God doing just about anything in the church. Believers who have a daily prayer time which they are faithful to, never backslide!

When we are tempted to sin the fact that we know we are meeting with God the next morning keeps us from committing sin. A believer who is consistent in prayer knows; sin causes them to dread their prayer time.

Psalm 24:3-4 (NLT) "*Who may climb the mountain of the LORD? Who may stand in his holy place? 4 Only those whose hands and hearts are pure, who do not worship idols and never tell lies."*

Daily prayer produces purity in our lives. Holiness is still the order of the day! **Matthew 5:8 (NKJV)**

"Blessed are the pure in heart, For they shall see God."

We should develop a consistent prayer life in an effort of maintaining a life of purity! 1 John 3:2-3 (**LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE**) (NKJV)

"Beloved, now we are children of God; and it has not

yet been revealed what we shall be, but we know that when He is revealed, we shall be like Him, for we shall see Him as He is.³ And everyone who has this hope in Him purifies himself, just as He is pure."

PRAYER IS REQUIRED; TO WALK IN FAITH!

Faith is a very important component in the life of a believer. **Hebrews 11:6** (KJV) "*But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him.*"

Prayer is essential in the development of faith.

Matthew 21:21-22 (NKJV) "*So Jesus answered and said to them, “Assuredly, I say to you, if you have faith and do not doubt, you will not only do what was done to the fig tree, but also if you say to this mountain, ‘Be removed and be cast into the sea,’ it will be done.”* **22** *“And whatever things you ask in prayer, believing, you will receive.”*

Every believer begins their spiritual walk with exactly the same amount of faith. **Romans 12:3** (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) (NKJV) "*... God has dealt to each one a measure of faith.*" **Romans 12:3** (KJV) "*... God hath dealt to every man the measure of faith.*" The level of faith a believer is capable of attaining depends how he goes about exercising his faith.

The exercising of faith is directly tied to our prayer life! **James 1:5-7** (NKJV) "*If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask of God, who gives to all liberally*

and without reproach, and it will be given to him.6 But let him ask in faith, with no doubting, for he who doubts is like a wave of the sea driven and tossed by the wind.7 For let not that man suppose that he will receive anything from the Lord."

We should pray, making our requests known to God. When He answers our prayer, our faith rises to a new level. Each prayer that we see answered enables us to believe God for larger things.

As we walk this process out, we are pleasing God! We should develop a prayer life in an effort of growing our faith!

PRAYER IS REQUIRED; TO WALK IN FREEDOM!

We live in a world that is in bondage on many fronts. People are grappling with addictions and phobias of all kinds. Sadly, the bondage of believers oftentimes mirrors that of the world. These things can be broken through the power of prayer.

Psalms 34 lays out the freedom God affords through prayer. [Psalm 34:4](#) (NLT) *"I prayed to the LORD, and he answered me, freeing me from all my fears."* I do not have time to read the entire chapter but I would like us to quickly examine several truths.

In this passage we are told that [the Lord will do the following things in response to the prayer of the believer](#): (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Deliver us from fear - Vs. 4

- Save us from our trouble - Vs.6
- Guard and deliver us - Vs. 7
- Be good to those who trust in Him - Vs. 8
- Supply all needs - Vs. 9
- Hear us when we pray - Vs. 15
- Redeem us - Vs. 22

We are to receive these things through: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Crying out to Him - Vs. 6&17
- Trusting Him - Vs. 8
- Fearing Him - Vs. 7&9
- Refraining from lying - Vs. 13
- Humbling ourselves - Vs. 18
- Serving Him - Vs. 18

God promises great blessings to his people, but many of these blessings require our active participation. In this instance our participation is a consistent prayer life.

If we hope to live free we must be people of prayer.

PRAYER IS REQUIRED; TO PERSEVERE!

My definition of persistence is the steadfast determination to complete a task without regard to the sacrifice.

By its nature the Christian life demands a boat load of persistence. Any achievement worthy of the effort it requires, merits the investment. I believe two things are required for a Christian to make the commitment

necessary to persist in achieving the will of God:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Become people of prayer... Persistent people are prayerful people... Prayerlessness produces a lack of persistence... The reason? Because persistence is born out of intimacy; intimacy with God is not possible without a prayer life.
- Know whom we serve and whose vision we are striving for... 2 Timothy 1:11-14 (NKJV) "... *I am appointed a preacher, an apostle, and a teacher of the Gentiles.12 For this reason I also suffer these things; nevertheless I am not ashamed, for I know whom I have believed and am persuaded that He is able to keep what I have committed to Him until that Day. 13 Hold fast the pattern of sound words which you have heard from me, in faith and love which are in Christ Jesus.14 That good thing which was committed to you, keep by the Holy Spirit who dwells in us."*

Winston Churchill said, *"The reason a bulldogs nose is slanted backward is so he can breathe while he holds on!"*

The church has far too many figureheads, deadheads and hotheads! We must become people who have hearts ablaze to do the will of God! We must have bull dog tenacity in pursuing the purposes of God!

We should pray because it will cause us to be steady and persistent!

PRAYER IS REQUIRED; TO HAVE POWER WITH GOD!

Most people would like to have power with God; the problem with this? There are no shortcuts to God's power supply. **The path to Gods power house leads through His prayer room! (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** No prayer; no power. This probably answers the question heard echoing through churches all across America... *"Where are the miracles?"*

"What must we do to see His miracles?"

Prayer is not a requirement strictly confined to the New Testament! Prior to performing miracles, Moses found it necessary to spend time in the presence of God! Where did God first speak to Moses? On the backside of the desert, alone, in the presence of God! In addition, look at this... Exodus 10:1-2 (NKJV) ***"Now the LORD said to Moses, 'Go in to Pharaoh; for I have hardened his heart and the hearts of his servants, that I may show these signs of Mine before him,² 'and that you may tell in the hearing of your son and your son's son the mighty things I have done in Egypt, and My signs which I have done among them, that you may know that I am the LORD.'**"*

Jesus spoke of His desire for His people to continue the string of miracles he had begun. Mark 16:17-18 (NKJV) ***"And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new tongues;¹⁸ 'they will take up serpents; and if they drink anything deadly, it will by***

no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover."

Cindy Davis, author and school teacher from Hampton, Virginia, said, *"The most amazing thing about a miracle is that it can't happen until all else has failed. That's God's favorite time to work."*

Why do you suppose God set the distribution of miracles up in a way that they flow through those who pray? (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Praying people are intimately connected to God to the point of developing a heart like Him...
- Praying people see things like God sees them...
- Praying people hear things like God hears them...
- Praying people are humble, not allowing pride to enter when a miracle occurs...

The prayers of righteous people are a source of great power to the world. James 5:16-18 (NKJV) *"Confess your trespasses to one another, and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The effective, fervent prayer of a righteous man avails much."¹⁷ Elijah was a man with a nature like ours, and he prayed earnestly that it would not rain; and it did not rain on the land for three years and six months."¹⁸ And he prayed again, and the heaven gave rain, and the earth produced its fruit."*

We should pray so we will be capable of allowing God to dispense miracles through us to a world who desperately needs them!

CONCLUSION:

I want to close with a challenge to practical application: Will you commit yourself to begin each day with fifteen minutes of prayer?

(LEAVE THIS QUESTION UP FOR REMAINDER OF CLASS)

WHY READ THE BIBLE?

(New Believers 101 - 3 of 8)

BLUE – POWER POINT PRESENTATION

BROWN – INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: [Joshua 1:8](#) (NKJV) *"This Book of the Law shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate in it day and night, that you may observe to do according to all that is written in it. For then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will have good success."*

[Psalm 119:96-106](#) (NKJV) *"I have seen the consummation of all perfection, But Your commandment is exceedingly broad. 97 Oh, how I love Your law! It is my meditation all the day. 98 You, through Your commandments, make me wiser than my enemies; For they are ever with me. 99 I have more understanding than all my teachers, For Your testimonies are my meditation. 100 I understand more than the ancients, Because I keep Your precepts. 101 I have restrained my feet from every evil way, That I may keep Your word. 102 I have not departed from Your judgments, For You Yourself have taught me. 103 How sweet are Your words to my taste, Sweeter than honey to my mouth! 104 Through Your precepts I get understanding; Therefore I hate every false way. 105 Your word is a lamp to my feet And a light to my path. 106 I have sworn and confirmed That I will keep Your righteous judgments."*

Speaking to Judas, not Iscariot, Jesus said, [John 14:23-24](#) (NKJV) ***"If anyone loves Me, he will keep My word; and My Father will love him, and We will come to him and make Our home with him."***²⁴ ***"He who does not love Me does not keep My words; and the word which you hear is not Mine but the Father's who sent Me."***

INTRO: The Bible is often referred to as the Word of God. The reason we refer to this book in this way is because that's exactly what it is; The Word of God.

Christians who believe the Bible to be the Word of God will automatically esteem the importance of reading it on a regular basis. Every Christian should develop a systematic approach to Bible reading. If it is the Word of God we should read it every day. The BIBLE can be defined in the following way:

B - Basic

I – Instruction

B – Before

L – Leaving

E- Earth

The fact that we are all very busy is certainly not lost on me; however, we must carve out some room for the Word of God in our busy schedules. If we do this, we will soon discover that a systematic reading of the Scriptures give answers to current difficulties.

In our daily Bible reading we will receive answers for yesterday's [questions](#). We will also find solutions for tomorrow's [dilemma](#), which we have not yet anticipated. How is this possible? [Hebrews 4:12](#) (NKJV) ***"For the word of God is living and powerful, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the division of soul and spirit, and of joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart."***

Most of us give very little consideration to the [various food groups](#) while planning our daily menu. We eat and [allow our body to process the nutrients, proteins, and vitamins that it needs](#).

We rarely say: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- I need to eat some [carbohydrates](#) to feed my brain today
- I need to eat some [fruit](#) for the antioxidants; vitamins which they provide
- I need to eat some [vegetables](#) for the fiber which they provide
- I need to eat some [meat & protein](#) - Poultry, fish, dry beans, eggs and nuts for the maintenance of my muscles
- I need to eat some [dairy products](#) today to keep my bones, teeth and nails healthy
- I need to eat some [fats](#) today to line and cushion the internal organs

The human body is an awesome machine. It is capable of taking the food we eat and converting it into what we need to sustain a quality life. It is also capable of dispensing the food we eat to the various areas of our bodies to be processed into brain cells, muscle, vitamins, protein, energy, etc... When we read the Bible the Spirit becomes the processor sending the Word throughout our entire being, thus supplying all our need! [Ephesians 4:16](#) (NKJV) *"From whom the whole body, joined and knit together by what every joint supplies, according to the effective working by which every part does its share, causes growth of the body for the edifying of itself in love."*

Though there are hundreds of reasons to consistently read the Word of God, I want to look at just a few of them...

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE BECAUSE IT IS DIVINELY INSPIRED AND INFALLIBLE!

In this post modern culture many religious leaders and denominations are waffling on the issues of inspiration and inerrancy. I want to be very clear on my stand with regard to these issues, I believe the Bible to be both divinely inspired and infallible.

If we allow our belief on these two issues to be eroded we fail to have a basis for faith and practice. If we cannot believe in the inspiration and infallibility of Scripture, how can we believe anything the Bible say's? In my mind, we must believe all of it, or none of it!

From a practical point of view think of this: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The Bible contains 66 books, divided into the Old and New Testaments - 39 in the Old and 27 in the New
- The word testament means covenant or contract
- The old contract; the new contract
- The Bible was written by more than 40 authors over a time span of 1500 years
- The Bible was written by shepherds, farmers, tent-makers, physicians, fishermen, priests, philosophers and kings; yet it does not contradict itself even once
- The Bible has been translated into more than 2,000 languages, with countless more partial translations, and audio translations - In comparison, Shakespeare, considered by many to be the master writer of the English language, has only been translated into 50 languages
- The Bible is still the best seller of all time

From a spiritual point of view the Bible states its own divine inspiration and infallibility: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- 2 Timothy 3:16 (NKJV) "All Scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness, 17 that the man

of God may be complete, thoroughly equipped for every good work."

- 2 Peter 1:21 (KJV) *"For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost."*

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE TO RECEIVE KNOWLEDGE OF ETERNAL LIFE!

Eternal life is more important than natural life. Most of us spend much more time and resources on natural life, than eternal life. Our life here will last seventy or eighty years but the life that follows will last forever! Someone said *"forever is a very long time."* If the after life is going to last forever, then it should follow, that we allow a little more time and attention to be focused on making sure we are ready for the next step.

One way we do this is through a systematic reading of the Scriptures. The Bible not only reveals the presence of eternal life, but gives careful instructions on how to be ready for that promotion. 1 John 5:13 (NKJV)

"These things I have written to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may know that you have eternal life, and that you may continue to believe in the name of the Son of God."

The work of the Holy Spirit is absolutely critical in our walk with God. He begins His work in us by convicting us of our sins. John 16:5-8 (NKJV) ***"But now I go away to Him who sent Me, and none of you asks Me, 'Where are You going?'"***⁶ ***"But because I have said these things to you, sorrow has filled your***

*heart.*⁷ ***“Nevertheless I tell you the truth. It is to your advantage that I go away; for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you; but if I depart, I will send Him to you.***⁸ ***“And when He has come, He will convict the world of sin, and of righteousness, and of judgment.”***

Once He has convicted us, we are then made aware of the presence of sin within us. As a result, we become knowledgeable of our own mortality, which leads us to consideration of where we are going to spend eternity. This consideration almost always leads to salvation.

Once we are saved, the Holy Spirit, who is our teacher, brings the Word to life as we read it. 2 Corinthians 3:6 (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

(NKJV) ***“Who also made us sufficient as ministers of the new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit; for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.”***

When we begin to regularly read and understand the Word of God we become more and more aware of what our eternity is going to be like. Revelation 21:1-7 (NKJV) ***“Now I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away. Also there was no more sea.² Then I, John, saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband.³ And I heard a loud voice from heaven saying, “Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and He will dwell with them, and they shall be His people. God Himself will be with them and be their God.⁴ “And God will wipe away every tear from their eyes; there shall be no more death, nor sorrow, nor***

crying. There shall be no more pain, for the former things have passed away.”⁵ Then He who sat on the throne said, “Behold, I make all things new.” And He said to me, “Write, for these words are true and faithful.”⁶ And He said to me, “It is done! I am the Alpha and the Omega, the Beginning and the End. I will give of the fountain of the water of life freely to him who thirsts.”⁷ “He who overcomes shall inherit all things, and I will be his God and he shall be My son.”

Once we understand our eternity, we make preparations for the eventuality of our journey.

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE TO RECEIVE HOPE!

One of the most significant problems in our world today is hopelessness.

What is the answer for our society? The Word of God! Listen to what the Word has to say about a hopeless society. **Romans 15:4** (NKJV) ***"For whatever things were written before were written for our learning, that we through the patience and comfort of the Scriptures might have hope."***

It is amazing what a little hope will do!

Hope can: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Cause a plan for an abortion to result in the birth of a baby

- Convert suicidal thoughts into a plan for the future
- Turn a criminal into a law abiding citizen
- Transform a divorce into a loving marriage
- Change a financial flop into an overwhelming success
- Modify stress from a health problem into a testimony

Reading the Bible furnishes the believer with a daily dose of hope! When you visit a Doctor for the purpose of acquiring antibiotics to fight an infection he will often give what is referred to a “*bolus dose*”; this is a greater amount than the normal daily dose. The “*bolus dose*” is designed to give your body a jump start of antibiotics in an effort to fight the infection. When the daily doses of hope begin to accumulate, the believer no longer walks in doubt concerning the future, but moves energetically toward it.

The difficulties of life do not tend to sidetrack the believer who receives an adequate amount of hope through daily Bible reading. Hebrews 6:18-19 (NKJV) *"That by two immutable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we might have strong consolation, who have fled for refuge to lay hold of the hope set before us.19 This hope we have as an anchor of the soul, both sure and steadfast, and which enters the Presence behind the veil."*

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE TO HAVE IT IMPRINTED ON THE HEART!

The word imprinted means to fix firmly in the mind.
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) It can also mean a mark made by a printer or publisher. When a person makes a decision to have a tattoo placed on their body they are not making a temporary choice, they are making a lifelong decision. Many people do such things on the spur of the moment, or even in a state of inebriation. In such cases, the individual oftentimes live to regret such a decision. Once it is done it is almost impossible to correct.

According to the Scripture the reading and study of the Word of God carries with it a process of being imprinted on the heart. [Deuteronomy 6:4-8](#) (KJV)

"Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD: 5 And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might. 6 And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart: 7 And thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up. 8 And thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thine hand, and they shall be as frontlets between thine eyes."

Listen to this: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Vs. 6 *"And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart."* The inference here is that the Word of God will become imprinted on our hearts in the same way a tattoo is imprinted on a body; a brand is imprinted on an animal; an insignia is imprinted on a product. We should read our Bibles with the intention of the words of this book becoming irreversibly imprinted on our hearts!
- Vs. 7 *"Thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children."* We should read the Bible with an attention level that would be conducive to taking what we have read and teach it to our children. Remember, there are more ways to teach a lesson than holding a Bible study. Our kid's learn mostly by what they see us modeling.
- Vs. 7 *"Thou shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up."* When we read the Word of God on a regular basis it will be surprising how often we discover that it will fit perfectly into a conversation. We should look for opportunities to bring the Word into a conversation.
- Vs. 8 *"thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thine hand."* The implication here is that the person who stays in the Word will place its contents in a very visible place in their life. This instruction is referring to making a note on our

hand, or tying a string around our finger so as not to forget.

- Vs. 8 ***"They shall be as frontlets between thine eyes."*** This reference has to do with a farmer or rancher placing blinders on a horse or mule in order to limit the peripheral vision of the beast. (In case it has A.D.D.)

According to this passage of Scripture, when we read and study the Word of God, the effects of the Word will begin to chart out a course for our life. In fact, ***the knowledge of the Word is a deterrent to sin!*** Psalm 119:11 (NKJV) ***"Your word I have hidden in my heart, That I might not sin against You!"***

The imprinting of the Word in our hearts will result in the words of this book being on our ***lips***. Romans 10:8-10 (NKJV) ***"But what does it say? "The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart" (that is, the word of faith which we preach):9 that if you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you will be saved.10 For with the heart one believes unto righteousness, and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation."***

Illustration: If you have a cup that is completely full of water and someone bumps into you, it is inevitable; you will spill water on that person. When we go out into the world we will spill what we are full of on the world; we should spill the Word of God on them!

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE BECAUSE IT FURNISHES A LIGHT!

Darkness is in and of itself a terrible thing. Someone said, *"I am not afraid of the dark, I am afraid of what is in it!"* This illustration bears out the very nature of darkness.

I want to point out the following facts about darkness:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Darkness brings with it the fear of the unknown and unseen
- Darkness is used as a cloak for danger - John 3:19-21 (NKJV) *"... The Light from heaven came into the world, but they loved the darkness more than the Light, for their deeds were evil. 20 They hated the heavenly Light because they wanted to sin in the darkness. They stayed away from that Light for fear their sins would be exposed and they would be punished. 21 But those doing right come gladly to the Light to let everyone see that they are doing what God wants them to."*
- Darkness conceals opportunity
- Darkness impedes progress

Light is the only deterrent to darkness. Psalm 119:130 (NKJV) *"The entrance of Your words gives light; It gives understanding to the simple."*

Light illuminates the desired area of vision and dispels darkness. (Use a flashlight to illustrate this point)
Psalm 19:8 (NKJV) *"The statutes of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart; The commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes."* (Stumbling over Jason's toys in the middle of the night)

Because we live in a world that is very dark, we are constantly in need of light! How do we receive the light which we so desperately need? Psalm 119:105 (NKJV) *"Your word is a lamp to my feet And a light to my path."*

2 Peter 1:17-21 (NKJV) *"And we heard this voice which came from heaven when we were with Him on the holy mountain.19 And so we have the prophetic word confirmed, which you do well to heed as a light that shines in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts;"* (Use the Bible as a flashlight)

The [light](#) of God is the [Word](#) of God! If we want to be enlightened in a dark culture we must be students of the Word of God!

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE BECAUSE IT HAS THE POTENTIAL TO PURIFY OUR LIFE!

Every Christian would no doubt readily agree; the will of God is for us to live a life that is pure before the Lord. Before we can live a pure life we must first experience the freedom that only God can provide.

[John 8:31-32](#) (NKJV) *"Then Jesus said to those Jews who believed Him, **"If you abide in My word, you are***

My disciples indeed.³² “And you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.” What is the truth spoken of in this Scripture? [John 17:17 \(NKJV\)](#)
“Sanctify them by Your truth. Your word is truth.”

We hear a great deal about freedom in our day, but not many people ever experience real freedom. The only people who can experience this freedom are those who know, understand and accept the Word of God!

Freedom has very little to do with where you live or what kind of government you live under. You can live in a democracy and never experience freedom! You can live under a harsh dictatorship and experience freedom! What is the difference? How we relate to His Word!

Once we become free, we must live free, not bringing ourselves back under bondage. Psalm 119:9 (NKJV)
“How can a young man cleanse his way? By taking heed according to Your word.” Charles Spurgeon once said, *“If you see a person whose Bible is falling apart, they probably have a life which is not.”*

The Word of God purifies our life! John 15:3 (NKJV)
“You are already clean because of the word which I have spoken to you.” Ephesians 5:25-26 (NKJV)
“Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself for her,²⁶ that He might sanctify and cleanse her with the washing of water by the word,” The Word of God is to the child of God, what a shower is to the physical body.

I promise you, you cannot pray and read your Bible every day and continue sinning.

WE SHOULD READ THE BIBLE FOR THE PURPOSE OF RECEIVING SEED!

Most of us are aware of the truth that there will not be a harvest unless seed has been sown. Based on this fact, sowing time is at least as important as harvest time. (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

In our spiritual walk we are instructed to do both; sow and reap! Most of us prefer reaping over sowing! Sowing seed is not nearly as exciting or sensational as harvesting! One thing I learned while pastoring in a farming community is that you never schedule special events during sowing time or harvest time. (Experience of helping to irrigate soy beans & driving a combine...)

If we are to sow seed, we must first receive seed.

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) What is the seed we are to be sowing? Jesus identifies the seed in the parable of the sower and the seed... Mark 4:1-9, 14-20 (NKJV) *"And again He began to teach by the sea. And a great multitude was gathered to Him, so that He got into a boat and sat in it on the sea; and the whole multitude was on the land facing the sea.2 Then He taught them many things by parables, and said to them in His teaching:3 **"Listen! Behold, a sower went out to sow.4 "And it happened, as he sowed, that some seed fell by the wayside; and the birds of the air came and devoured it.5 "Some fell on stony ground, where it did not have much earth;***

and immediately it sprang up because it had no depth of earth.⁶ “But when the sun was up it was scorched, and because it had no root it withered away.⁷ “And some seed fell among thorns; and the thorns grew up and choked it, and it yielded no crop.⁸ “But other seed fell on good ground and yielded a crop that sprang up, increased and produced: some thirtyfold, some sixty, and some a hundred.”... 14 “The sower sows the word.¹⁵ “And these are the ones by the wayside where the word is sown. When they hear, Satan comes immediately and takes away the word that was sown in their hearts.¹⁶ “These likewise are the ones sown on stony ground who, when they hear the word, immediately receive it with gladness;¹⁷ “and they have no root in themselves, and so endure only for a time. Afterward, when tribulation or persecution arises for the word’s sake, immediately they stumble.¹⁸ “Now these are the ones sown among thorns; they are the ones who hear the word,¹⁹ “and the cares of this world, the deceitfulness of riches, and the desires for other things entering in choke the word, and it becomes unfruitful.²⁰ “But these are the ones sown on good ground, those who hear the word, accept it, and bear fruit: some thirtyfold, some sixty, and some a hundred.”

We cannot very well sow seed without first receiving seed. We receive seed by becoming a student of the Word of God: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- [Daily Bible reading](#)

- Studying the Word
- Attending a discipleship class which is based on the Word of God
- Submitting to a Pastor who preaches the Word

Once we have received the Word of God we should make sure our attitude in sowing is right! Psalm 126:6 (NKJV) *"He who continually goes forth weeping, Bearing seed for sowing, Shall doubtless come again with rejoicing, Bringing his sheaves with him."*

When a farmer sows seed he is limited by the amount of land he has set aside for sowing and the amount of seed he possesses. The believer experiences the exact same limitations. 2 Corinthians 9:8-10 (LB) *"For God, who gives seed to the farmer to plant, and later on good crops to harvest and eat, will give you more and more seed to plant and will make it grow so that you can give away more and more fruit from your harvest."* We must continually feed on the Word because it is seed and we are planters who need something to sow!

CONCLUSION:

Will you make a commitment to reading your Bible each day? (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF CLASS)

